

at a bargain price and then learning it is really the long-lost work of some great master. This does happen on occasion. I know, for it happened to me.

About 25 years ago, I attended an art sale at Sotheby's in London. Among the objects on sale was a rather battered Italian painting of a madonna—a work, the Sotheby experts declared, produced by some unknown artist.

Although the madonna was badly begrimed and in a poor state of preservation, I liked the picture; it was, I thought, reminiscent of Raphael. I bought it—for \$200.

In 1963, I decided to have the painting cleaned. The job was entrusted to the famous firm of restorers, Thomas Agnew & Sons. Representatives of the firm soon called me excitedly. The painting was, indeed, the work of Raphael, they said—and this was quickly authenticated by such leading art experts as Alfred Scharf. The painting I purchased for \$200 has proved to be Raphael's *Madonna*

d i Loreto, painted in 1508-1509. Its real value: upwards of a million dollars.

I'll grant there isn't much likelihood that the average art buyer will pick up a \$300,000 Gauguin, a \$155,000

Braque or even a \$1500 Tiepolo for pennies in a corner junk shop. On the other hand, such remarkable finds as a London art critic's recent discovery in a Dublin shed of five soot-blackened canvases which proved to be important Guardi figure compositions serve to keep all art buyers'

hopes high.

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Certainly, it is often possible to buy good, reasonably priced works by lesser artists, particularly in out-of-the-way art stores, antique shops, and even second-hand bookstores, which are frequently excellent places to pick up prints and etchings. Then, of course, one can shop very advantageously for the works of talented young artists who have not yet arrived, but who